



Saint-Petersburg School of Social Sciences

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Factors Shaping Support for Israel Among Democratic Members of the House of Representatives in the Conditions of the Israeli-Palestinian Crisis

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Problem and Research Questions

1. What factors drive the variation in Democratic legislators' support for Israel across both public framing and substantive roll-call voting?
2. To what extent does AIPAC contributions associate with a legislator's propensity to express pro-Israel framing and cast substantive roll-call votes?
3. How does a legislator's public framing of the conflict correspond to their actual substantive roll-call voting?



House Speaker Nancy Pelosi speaks at the annual American Israel Public Affairs Committee (AIPAC) conference on March 26, 2019 in Washington, DC.



Theoretical Framework 1

- Reelection and political survival (Mayhew, 1974)

H1: A district's PVI shapes a legislator's formal and informal behavior: higher (more Republican) PVI scores associates with Democratic representatives adopting more pro-Israel positions.

- Home Style Theory (Fenno, 2003): a politician represents local constituency interests

H2: The proportion of the Jewish population within a district positively associates with pro-Israel positioning.

- Exogenous Shocks & Cross-Pressure (Arnold, 1990): exogenous shocks create cross-pressure between grassroots protestors and AIPAC



Theoretical Framework 2

- Digital "Cheap Talk" (Farrell & Rabin, 1996): Donors need constant positive image constitution

H3: Informal digital rhetoric acts as cheap talk to maintain the long-term image expected by donors. A legislator's Twitter stance remains highly stable against short-term protest shocks and is associated with AIPAC contributions.

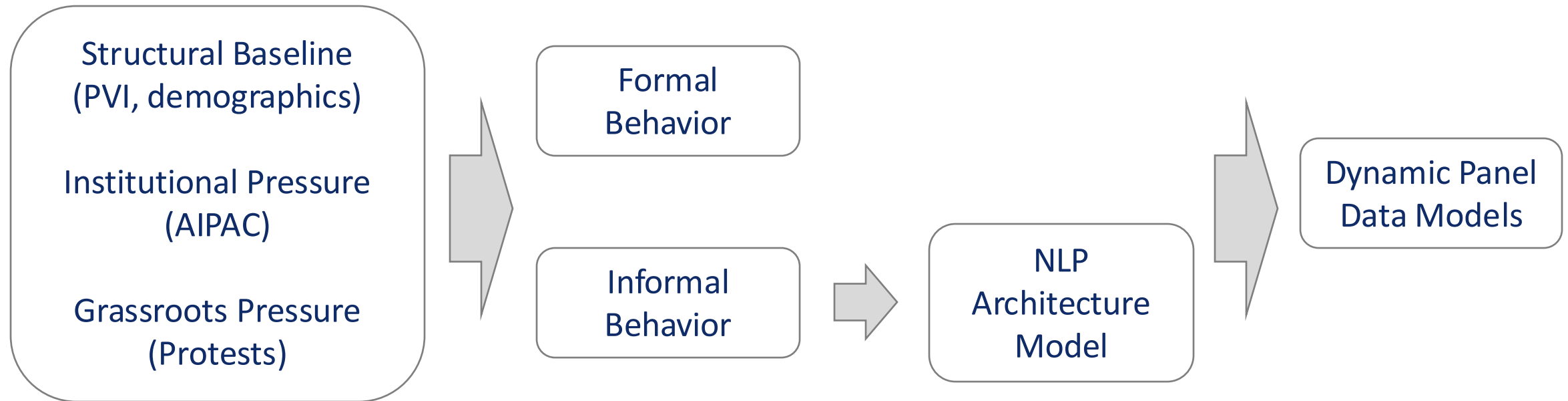
- Institutional Decoupling (Lee, 2016): symbolic bills (e.g., which will receive a veto) VS substantive bills (with political consequences)

H4: During periods of high issue salience, formal behavior on symbolic messaging votes is driven by grassroots mobilization: pro-Israel protests associated with the increase of the probability of a "Yea" vote, whereas pro- Palestine protests associated with opposition.

H5: When transitioning to substantive legislation, the association of grassroots protests evaporates, and formal legislative behavior becomes associated with contributions from AIPAC.



Research Design





Methods 1

$$\text{Logit}\left(P(V_{i,t} = 1)\right) = \beta_0 + \rho V_{i,t-1} + \beta_1 \Delta \text{Protests}_{i,t} + \beta_2 \text{AIPAC}_i + \beta_3 \text{PVI}_i + \beta_4 \text{JewishPop}_i + \gamma X_i + \epsilon_{i,t}$$

Where:

- $P(V_{i,t} = 1)$ is the probability of legislator i voting “Yea” in the current period t .
- $V_{i,t-1}$ is the lagged dependent variable (the legislator’s vote in the previous period $t-1$).
- $\Delta \text{Protests}_{i,t}$ represents the exogenous shock: the volume of protests in the legislator’s district occurring strictly between period $t-1$ and period t .



Methods 2

- CNN: Sweeps across word matrices to extract local patterns and key n-grams.
- BiGRU: Scans the text sequence bidirectionally to capture hidden context and long-term dependencies.
- FastText: Averages word embeddings to identify core semantics, handling noise and slang.
- Meta-Learner: Merges these three independent representations to make the final classification.

Layer (type)	Output Shape	Param #	Connected to
input_layer (InputLayer)	(None, 500)	0	-
embedding (Embedding)	(None, 500, 100)	10,000,000	input_layer[0][0]
dropout (Dropout)	(None, 500, 100)	0	embedding[0][0]
conv1d (Conv1D)	(None, 498, 128)	38,528	dropout[0][0]
bidirectional (Bidirectional)	(None, 500, 128)	63,744	dropout[0][0]
global_max_pooling... (GlobalMaxPooling1...)	(None, 128)	0	conv1d[0][0]
global_max_pooling... (GlobalMaxPooling1...)	(None, 128)	0	bidirectional[0]...
global_average_poo... (GlobalAveragePool...)	(None, 100)	0	dropout[0][0]
concatenate (Concatenate)	(None, 356)	0	global_max_pooli... global_max_pooli... global_average_p...
dense (Dense)	(None, 64)	22,848	concatenate[0][0]
dropout_1 (Dropout)	(None, 64)	0	dense[0][0]
dense_1 (Dense)	(None, 3)	195	dropout_1[0][0]

NLP Classification Model Design



Data

Formal Behavior Data

- H.R. 6126 (\$14.3B) – Symbolic (Presidential veto).
- H.R. 7217 (\$17.6B) – Symbolic (Presidential veto).
- H.R. 8034 (\$26.0B) – Substantive.

Informal Behavior Data

- Twitter Corpus: 6,068 raw posts from Democratic representatives.
- Training Set: 1,000 manually coded tweets to train the Meta-Learner.

Independent Variables

- AIPAC contributions; PVI; Jewish Population %; Pro-/Anti-Israel protests.

Bill	D Yea	D %	D Nay	R Yea	R %	R Nay
H.R. 6126	12	5.8%	192	214	96.8%	2
H.R. 7217	46	22.1%	162	204	93.2%	14
H.R. 8034	170	81.7%	35	195	88.6%	21
Mean	76.0	36.5%	129.7	204.3	92.9%	12.3

Voting on Aid to Israel by Party



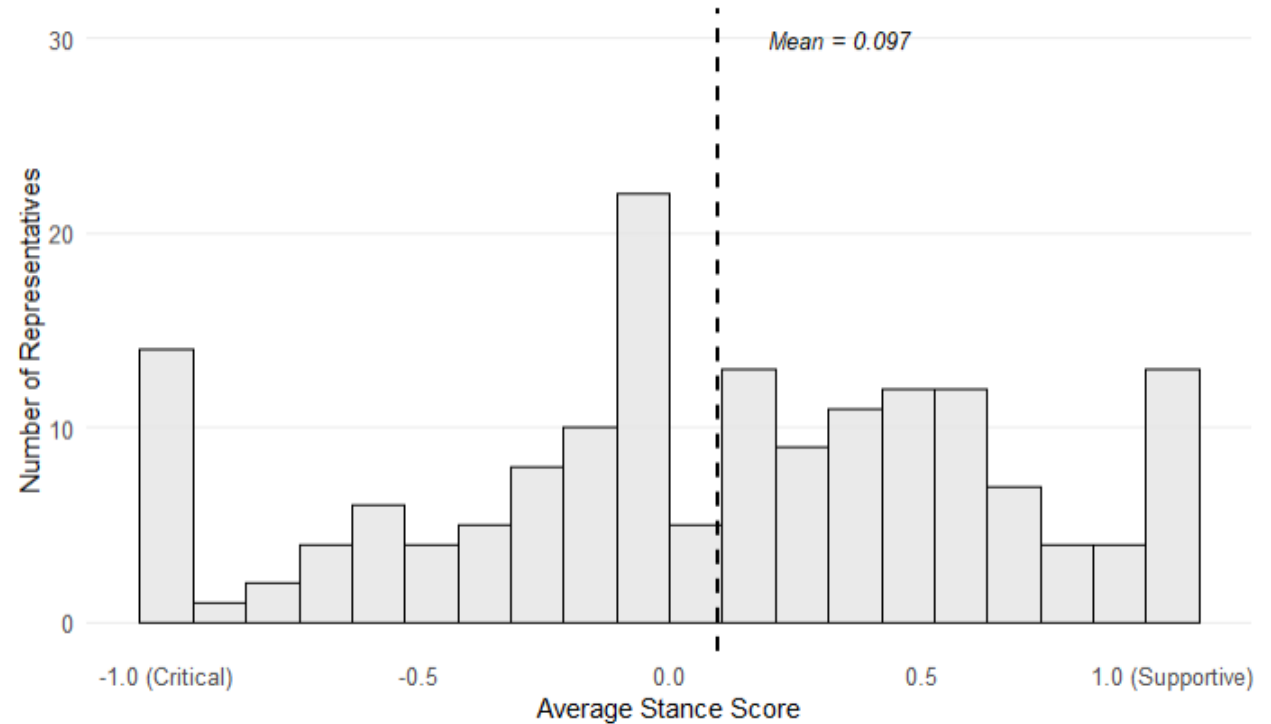
Results 1: Descriptive Statistics of Informal Behavior

Performance by Category:

- Critical (-1): Precision = 0.60 | Recall = 0.64
- Neutral (0): Precision = 0.74 | Recall = 0.70
- Pro-Israel (1): Precision = 0.88 | Recall = 0.89

The custom deep learning ensemble outperforms the baseline linear model by 1.6%

However linear model has better interpretability



Distribution of Twitter Stance on Israel among Democrats



Results 2: Predictors of Informal Behavior

	Stance V2 (Base: V1)	Stance V3 (Base: V2)
Intercept	0.061 (0.087)	0.072 (0.059)
Previous Stance (Up to V1)	<u>0.842***</u> (0.044)	
Previous Stance (Up to V2)		<u>0.883***</u> (0.030)
Male (vs Female)	0.018 (0.039)	-0.010 (0.029)
Black (vs White)	0.061 (0.060)	0.015 (0.043)
Hispanic (vs White)	-0.080 (0.057)	0.002 (0.044)
Asian (vs White)	0.022 (0.071)	0.041 (0.055)
Jewish (vs White)	0.047 (0.070)	0.059 (0.049)
PVI (Cook Index)	0.683** (0.249)	0.119 (0.178)
District Jewish Pop %	-0.168 (0.598)	0.009 (0.421)
AIPAC Contributions (Std)	0.030 (0.018)	0.016 (0.012)
New Pro-Israel Protests (V2, Log)	<u>0.010</u> (0.026)	
New Pro-Israel Protests (V3, Log)		<u>-0.022</u> (0.015)
New Pro-Palestine Protests (V2, Log)	<u>-0.001</u> (0.023)	
New Pro-Palestine Protests (V3, Log)		<u>-0.012</u> (0.014)
Num.Obs.	115	150
R2	0.835	0.909

	Stance Score
Intercept	0.195* (0.089)
Male (vs Female)	0.101 (0.082)
Black (vs White)	0.080 (0.115)
Hispanic (vs White)	0.017 (0.123)
Asian (vs White)	-0.063 (0.155)
Jewish (vs White)	0.060 (0.136)
PVI (Cook Index)	<u>1.900***</u> (0.472)
District Jewish Pop %	1.857 (1.089)
AIPAC Contributions (Std)	<u>0.114***</u> (0.034)
Num.Obs.	165
R2	0.262
R2 Adj.	0.219
RMSE	0.48
* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001	



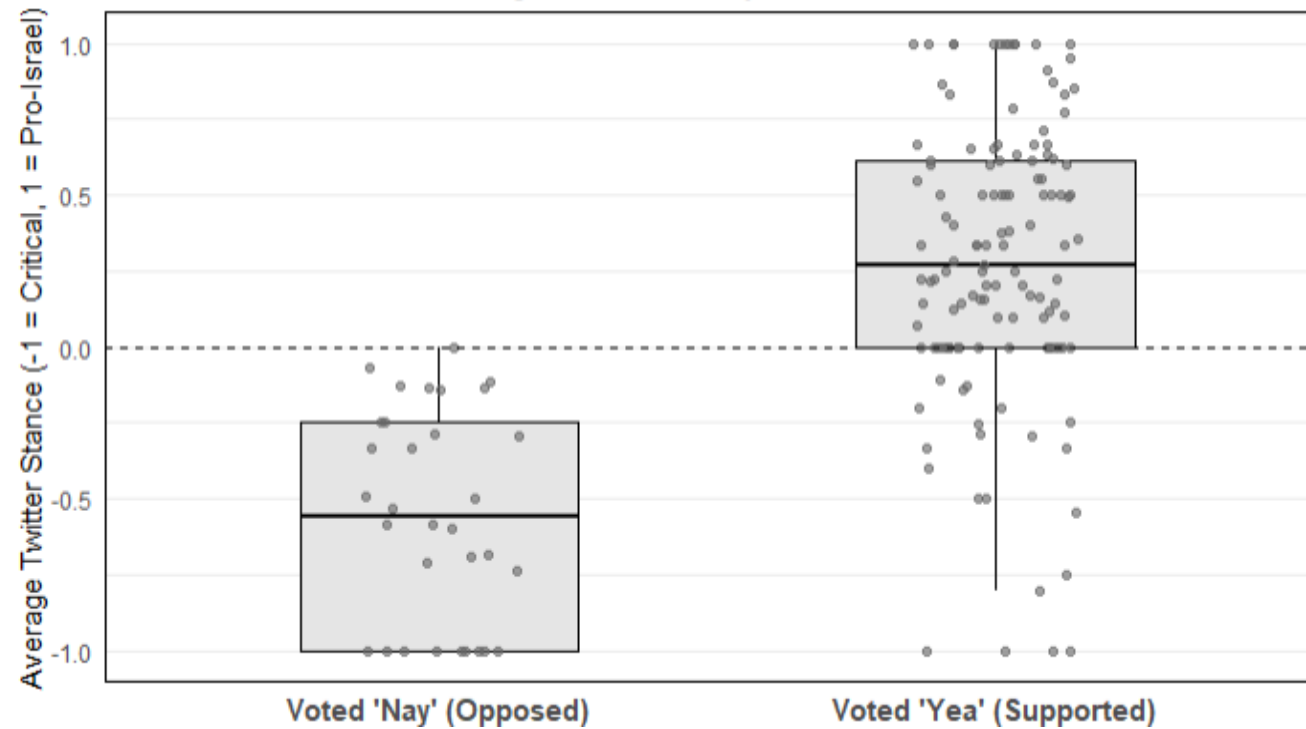
Results 3: Predictors of Formal Behavior

- Opposition remain the vote on symbolic bills, but shifts on the substantive vote (124 out of 160 switched to "Yea")
- Local protests significantly predict the vote for symbolic bills
- The association of protests evaporates when shift to substantive bills
- AIPAC contributions emerge as a highly significant predictor for substantive bills
- District PVI remains a strong positive predictor across all votes
- Jewish population proportion shows no significance

	V2 (Firth Logit)	V3 (Firth Logit)
Previous Vote (V1)	<u>5.017***</u> (1.444)	
Previous Vote (V2)		<u>2.946**</u> (1.310)
Male (vs Female)	0.967* (0.450)	-1.003* (0.509)
Black (vs White)	-0.387 (0.707)	-0.508 (0.661)
Hispanic (vs White)	1.425* (0.551)	-1.199 (0.725)
Asian (vs White)	0.759 (0.760)	-2.339** (0.891)
Jewish (vs White)	1.186 (0.715)	-0.292 (1.002)
PVI (Cook Index)	<u>6.073*</u> (2.522)	<u>6.536*</u> (2.951)
District Jewish Pop %	4.540 (5.814)	-12.823 (7.543)
AIPAC Contributions (Std)	0.218 (0.160)	<u>4.083***</u> (1.036)
New Pro-Israel Protests (V2, Log)	<u>0.671*</u> (0.299)	
New Pro-Israel Protests (V3, Log)		0.323 (0.251)
New Pro-Palestine Protests (V2, Log)	<u>-0.624*</u> (0.263)	
New Pro-Palestine Protests (V3, Log)		-0.104 (0.291)
Num.Obs.	203	204



Results 4: Strategic Decoupling



Distribution of digital stance scores by final roll-call vote on H.R. 8034

Limitations

- Informal behavior analysis is restricted to a limited X social media
- Accounts of Representatives could be managed by PR staff
- AIPAC financial data is cumulative, preventing the establishment of strict causality
- The exact timing of financial donations compared to political stances remains undetermined
- Models face potential omitted variable bias from the Military-Industrial Complex lobbying





Conclusion

- The strategic decoupling mechanism successfully suggests an explanation to political behavior under cross-pressure
- Informal digital rhetoric acts as stable "cheap talk" immune to protest shocks
- Formal behavior is highly conditional and depends entirely on the policy stakes
- Legislators offer symbolic concessions to the grassroots while delivering substantive votes to AIPAC